



Indo I did

Two *CLASSIC* luxurious resorts offer a perfect tasting plate of INDONESIA, the ultimate *accessible idyll*.

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The view across the infinity pool at Oberoi Lombok.

Two metres underwater, on the silty ocean floor off the coast of Lombok, Indonesia, lie hundreds of concrete hearts. They are scattered haphazardly, tossed about by the many currents and tides that massage the shore. Each heart is etched with newlyweds' names and dotted with small trees of staghorn coral glowing in impossible shades of phosphorescent blue, green and pink. Starfish recline lazily across barnacled stones, while furtive little bannerfish and parrotfish in their garish sequined costumes flit through intricate filigreed coral formations. It's as silent as a tomb down there; a beautiful and strange sort of graveyard.

This remarkable scene is all thanks to the Oberoi resort in Lombok, Bali's understated sister to its east, which offers honeymooning guests the chance to plant coral in a bid to repopulate the reef, and immortalise their union forever. The men from the local village of Jambe Anom carve the concrete hearts, which are used to anchor the coral trees to the ocean floor. The men take the newlyweds out in a brightly coloured

longboat and, armed with snorkels and reef shoes, the lovers swim down to place little coral trees in specially carved holders in the hearts. Their adventure is captured on an underwater camera and presented on a CD at the end of their trip.

The Oberoi has been planting coral out the front of the property's pretty little beach for the past seven years and the activity has done a lot to reinstate the natural habitat of the local sea life. "There are a lot more fish coming now, since we planted the coral," says general manager Rudy Baihaqi, a jovial Balinese man who clearly loves his job. "We tell our guests that they have planted a little baby and they must come back and check on it," he says with a hearty laugh.

Built in 1996, the Oberoi Lombok is a stunning resort situated across 10 hectares of tropical gardens on the north-west coast of Lombok. Its 20 villas and 30 pavilion rooms boast postcard-worthy views across Medana Bay and the emerald green gardens. The epic swimming pool and reflection ponds that step down the hill to the beach and shimmer with palm

tree reflections are an architectural nod to the ubiquitous rice paddies terraced into the volcanic mountainside.

The resort's vast 255-square-metre villas are built in traditional Balinese compound style with high stone walls circling either a lush, flowering garden or a generous plunge pool that features elevated pavilions offering alfresco dining with a view out to the beach or palms.

The expansive bedrooms include dreamy four-poster beds with billowing muslin mosquito nets and generous bathrooms opening onto private courtyards. Here's the chance to while away your days in fully secluded privacy.

Alternatively, if the mood takes you, catch a tour to the nearby trio of Gili Islands, where you can snorkel (and, perhaps, spot a rare hawksbill turtle), visit the relaxed community on Gili Trawangan and clip-clop around the island on a *cidomo*, a traditional pony-drawn cart. When its time for dinner there's a purpose-built private table in the bales (pavilions) by the pool where evening noises like the chirp of geckos give way to the last daily



Sunset by the pool,
Oberoi Bali.

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call to prayer echoing across the bay. (Lombok is mostly Muslim, unlike Bali, whose residents are traditionally Hindu).

After the utter tranquillity of Lombok, a visit to the Oberoi's sister resort in Bali is a double-espresso shot. With a delectable dining offering, eclectic shopping strip and stepped-up pace, the Oberoi Bali allows honeymooners to take baby steps from the remote beauty of Lombok back into the real world. For the ultimate Indonesian degustation, the resort offers a package that encourages guests to sample both properties. If you book six nights at both, with at least two at Lombok, the resort will pay for your flights (or ferry if you'd prefer) between Bali and Lombok.

Where Lombok is the shy but beautiful ingénue, Bali is the worldly older sister. And both are raised on all the pedigree and pomp that one would expect from one of the world's classic and exotic hotel groups (Oberoi has properties throughout India, Indonesia, Africa and the Middle East). Among the island's oldest and most majestic hotels, the Oberoi Bali sprawls across six hectares of tropical gardens that spill onto the lively Seminyak beach. The chaos and nightlife of the neighbouring resorts and bars feel a hundred miles away once you glide into the understated grandeur of the Oberoi.

"We like to think of her as the Grande Dame of Bali," says John Halpin, the resort's general manager over an excellent degustation in the Kura Kura restaurant. A fabulous raconteur from Massachusetts, Halpin first arrived in Bali in 1996 and knows just about everyone. "If Bali is Paris, then the Oberoi is the Crillon," he

says definitively of the resort that has wrapped everyone from David Bowie to Julia Roberts in linen-lined luxury.

The property consists of 14 villas and 60 Lanai rooms, similar in feel to the Lombok rooms. Both resorts were designed by Australian architect Peter Muller, and strike the perfect balance between traditional and modern.

Hidden behind high coral walls (a rare sight now that harvesting coral is illegal), covered in moss and fringed with trees, is your own tropical oasis of hibiscus, bougainvillea, palms and bird of paradise – and two cushy sunbeds from which to admire it all. And then there's the bathroom, with a sunken marble bathtub rimmed with candles that looks out to an atrium complete with a lotus pond and tiny

fish. A separate shower and toilet on either side also open into the little garden.

Take a tour into the hills of Ubud and watch local silversmiths, woodcarvers and jewellers work their magic, or simply beach yourself next to the pool and dine on deluxe nasi goreng. Small details make all the difference in an Oberoi hotel, so it seems almost normal that as you stretch out on the sun lounge your pool butler arrives with chilled towels, water and sunscreen. That's just the start – frangipani flowers on your pillow before bedtime, a bath adorned with flowers, your cosmetics placed just so, your shoes by the door ready to step straight into ... Oberoi's Bali and Lombok resorts really do tick every box. No long-haul flight required. ■

Go to www.oberoihotels.com.



The Totek Bar,
Oberoi Lombok.